

No Place

Hiroko's phone light lit up the hall before her, the moon's faint glow bleeding through the lattice walls. The thump rang out again; soft. Imperceptible if it weren't for the silence of the countryside. She crept forward, fed up and ready to confront the source of this noise.

She had been against the move from the beginning. Her dad had gotten a promotion, but what kind of promotion forces you to move to some isolated old countryside? Takayama was nice, but there was nothing for Hiroko to do besides sulk. She barely had any time to say goodbye to her friends back in Kyoto before they were off. And what does she get in return? A fancy new private school where the girls are uptight and the boys think she's weird. No parks nearby, no arcades, no nothing. Just a sunny spot in the front yard to read books and a river a half-mile away to throw rocks into.

She was careful not to step on any of the particularly creaky floorboards as she tiptoed down the hall, wire glasses hanging loosely off the bridge of her nose. Her mom would kill her if she knew Hiroko was up this late, but Hiroko needed to figure out what that thumping noise was. It had been happening every night since they moved in. Her mom would tuck her into bed, she'd lie awake for an hour, then the noise would start up. It was soft at first, and she'd be on the precipice of sweet sleep each time it began. But nonetheless, it would start. A light tapping, like the plinking of water on metal. Then slowly, it would get louder. It would grow into a thump, each one seeming close but dampened, as though it was coming from below the floorboards.

Hiroko had brought it up to her mother on their second day there.

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"You were probably just imagining it," she said in that falsely tender tone all mothers use with defiant children. She always spoke that way.

"I'm not, I swear! It was real and it kept me up all night." Her mother looked down at her mug of morning tea, swirling it softly before taking a sip. She seemed uninterested in the conversation.

"Well honey, maybe it was just the house settling, or some animal outside," she said after a pause. The two were sitting out on the front porch, gazing out at the rolling hills before them. The sun was always too bright in the early morning, but it did a good job illuminating the golden grass fields. Hiroko was waiting for her mother to finish eating breakfast so she could drive her to school.

"It wasn't! It sounded really close, like it was right next to me!" Hiroko pleaded. Her mother was used to dismissing her concerns, especially after the move.

"Hiroko, there was no bumping, okay? It was just your imagination playing tricks on you. You're just getting used to the new house, and these things happen when you're falling asleep," she said, now clearly impatient with her daughter's insistence.

Hiroko began wishing she had told her father about the noises instead. At least he would've pretended to believe her. He was always at work after the move though, and the only time Hiroko got to see him was when he came home after dinner and went straight to bed. She couldn't imagine he had time to even talk with her mother anymore. Back in Kyoto, she would sometimes overhear the two whispering to each other after putting her to bed. They were quiet, but loud enough for her to make out their soft tones and tender intonations. Now all she heard at night was the thumping.

The family room was empty, the silence only broken by the occasional soft thump. Hiroko felt the cold wood against her bare feet, clutching softly to her pajama pants as the courage that got her to this point was quickly dissipating. After months of this constant thumping however, her curiosity had transformed into something much more motivating. Irritation. She dropped down silently to her knees, resting an ear against the cool floor, hearing the thump a little more clearly than before. It was certainly louder in the family room than it was in her bedroom. She waved her phone around the empty room, illuminating its contents. A short cedar dresser sat against the far wall, flat against the floor, flanked by a television and a lowered dining table. The dresser always seemed somewhat off to Hiroko, like it was placed there just to fill space. She couldn't say for sure if her parents even used it for anything.

Creeping slowly across the floor, Hiroko pushed her ear against the dresser. The noise bumped out, sounding much clearer than ever before. She pulled her head back, nervous and a little stunned, but feeling a jolt of excitement shoot through her small body. Hiroko eagerly pulled open the top drawer, expecting to find some toy or small machine, or a little caged up rodent. What she saw instead gave her a pause she hadn't expected. Her initial assessment was almost correct, the drawer was mostly empty. Stacked neatly in the middle of its small wooden frame however was a small pile of photographs.

She took them carefully, examining the laminated images. They were photos of her parents back when they lived in Kyoto: her mother tending to her potted plants on the windowsill (their old house was too small to have a garden), her father asleep on the couch with the tv on, the both of them standing in the kitchen and smiling at the camera. It looked like her father had taken that last one of the both of them. Hiroko felt an odd sense of unease looking at these photos, though perhaps it was melancholy. She hadn't seen her mother smile like that since they moved to the new place, granted she hadn't smiled that much to begin with. The few times she had actually seen her father after the move, he seemed drained of life. He still smiled, but it was like something in him had been lost. He would say good morning to her mother, give her that strained smile, and then he'd be gone.

The photo of her father's genuine smiling made her think about the few times she had gotten to speak with him since they had moved. Of course, she had brought up the thumping to him too.

"Oh yeah, your mother told me about that. And it hasn't gone away?" Her father's voice was deep, gruff, but calm. It was pleasant in a way that was hard to describe, like the perfect combination of milk and coffee.

"Nope, in fact it's only gotten louder," Hiroko said. She was sitting in the sunny patch on the lawn, picking listlessly at the grass. Her father put his fist to his chin in a comical manner, as if pondering some great mystery.

"Hmmm. It could be a leaky faucet, or maybe the water pipes are just making noise," he said. Those answers made sense to Hiroko, but she knew that wasn't the case. She had checked all the faucets in the house after the first week of thumping. She knew what pipes sounded like, and this wasn't it. She didn't know how to explain it to him though, and opted instead to let the issue be, pretending to be satisfied by his explanation.

"How have you been enjoying school?" he said, finally breaking the silence that had accumulated between them. They had been in Takayama for close to three weeks now, but this was the first time they had a chance to talk. The sun rippled on the horizon as it lowered behind the distant cliffs. Hiroko wished her dad would come home early every night, maybe then her mother wouldn't constantly be asking Hiroko to keep her company.

"It's alright I guess," she said, going back to pick at the grass. "The work isn't too hard, but I miss Masako, and Katsumi, and... everyone." Her father let out an audible sigh, clearly having expected a similar answer.

"Well sweetie, have you tried making new friends?"

"I've tried, but all the girls at school are mean, rude jerks! They make fun of me for my short hair and call me a loser." This was a lie. Hiroko hadn't said a word to her classmates since they moved. She wasn't confident enough to strike up a conversation with strangers, and part of her still held onto the hope that her parents would relent and move them back to Kyoto. She would get to spend time with her friends again, her parents would get to spend time with each other again. When she brought the idea up to her mother she just brushed her off. Hiroko overheard her crying later that night before father got home.

"What!? I'd like to give that kid a piece of my mind," her father said, putting up his arms in a fighting stance. Hiroko giggled softly, before the two were interrupted by her mother. Dinner was ready.

Hiroko let out an indignant huff, disappointed with her lack of noise-related findings. The thump rang out again, seeming to come from the empty container. Hiroko's eyes widened as she got an idea. The dresser was luckily light enough for her twelve year-old self to pull away from the wall without too much effort, though at this point she had almost entirely forgotten about trying to be quiet. She could feel her breath catch in her throat as she revealed the wall behind the dresser, though she wasn't sure if this was due to excitement, shock, or fear.

Built into the wall was a small metal door, about half Hiroko's height. She had never seen it before, or heard her parents mention a door like this. The door had an indented handle, worn with age, its edges partially rusted over. As Hiroko examined the strange door, trying to make sense of it, she heard the bump again.

Louder.

It was coming from beyond the door. She slowly reached out a hand to grab the handle, flinching as her skin touched its surface. It was warm, not hot enough to hurt, but much hotter than would be expected given the general coolness of the rest of the house. Gathering up all the courage she could muster, Hiroko reached out once more to grab the handle.

A plume of steam billowed out as she opened the door, revealing a narrow, short hallway. The hallway was made of metal and piping, and lit by small red lights in the walls, bathing the whole scene in crimson. Hiroko fell back, staring perplexed at the industrial shaft before her. The hall was long, and there was no end in sight. Hiroko scrambled to close the door, but a new sound escaped the open door that stopped her. A whisper.

"Help..."

Hiroko froze, brain racing as she processed the strained words. They echoed out from the metal hall, quickly replaced by another thump that shook the walls. The voice was strange, but oddly recognizable, like a song long forgotten. Hiroko could feel her heart race, the walls of her own body shaking from its beats. She knelt down, calling out softly into the steamy entrance.

"H-hello? Who's there?" she said in a hushed tone, the reality of her situation suddenly making the room feel somehow more silent than it had already been. The voice didn't respond, and for a moment, Hiroko began questioning if she had even heard it in the first place.

"P-please... hurry..." The voice sounded haggard, rushed, desperate, familiar. Hiroko felt her limbs turn to jelly, barely able to hold herself up let alone move herself into the hall. But the pain she heard in the voice was too strong to ignore, and moving like one in a dream, she clawed away at the steam before her and slithered through the rusted metal door.

The hallways smelled like a locker room, beads of sweat forming on Hiroko's forehead as she crawled deeper through the metal tunnel. It was hot, but bearable. The steam fogged up her glasses, and she needed to pause every few feet to wipe them. The thumping continued at a consistent pace, though it was much clearer than it had been in her room. It was loud but dull, less like a crash or colliding metal, and more like the sound of a slowly beaten drum. Hiroko had

tried calling out to the voice a few more times since she entered, but had yet to receive another response.

The hallway was slowly opening up, ceiling growing taller and walls growing wider with each step. Hiroko slowly rose to her feet, walking forward at a quickened pace. Through the billowing steam she could see the hall turn right. The lights were dimmer here, and the thumping sounded close. Hiroko had to steady herself on the metal floor as she stepped in a small puddle, glancing down to see a circle of deep red liquid. She couldn't tell if the liquid was actually red however or if it was just a trick of the light. It felt sticky though, and her pace immediately slowed. Before she could process the situation, the voice called out again.

"Please... it... hurts so much..." Its voice was ragged, as if any remaining vocal chords it had were being stretched to their limit. The voice was loud though, and very close. It echoed in a bizarre pattern like two voices speaking at once. Two ruptured, but familiar voices. Hiroko held her breath at the hall's end, afraid to turn the corner for what she might see. Weakly, she moved her body forward, her heart dropping.

Before her stood a wall made of sinew and flesh, its skin bubbling up in places and flowing down in others like melting butter. The wall had a slit at its base, a mouth with no lips. Cracked stained teeth jutted out its reddened gums, though the wall had no tongue. Above its mouth sat a nose-like ridge, two slit-like nostrils opening and closing with each ragged breath it took. A pus-like liquid dribbled down the holes as they opened, a mix of blood and snot. Jutting out of the flesh above were two bulging eyes, bloodshot. It didn't look like the wall had any eyelids to speak of, leaving its eyes perpetually wide open. Tears streaked down its uneven face, and on regular intervals, the whole wall would pulsate—its face jutting out before receding back into place—in time with the soft thumping sounds.

"H-help... us..." it gasped out. Its voice was both gruff but tender, calm but sharp. It sounded like her parents. The wall's flesh crept along the adjacent metal walls in long muscly tendrils, as if consuming the surrounding hall. With each pulse, it seemed like it was slowly moving closer to her, blood leaking from each of its crevices.

Hiroko stood still for a moment, too horrified to process the image before her as being real. It was only when the wall's strands of flesh inched its way to brush against her bare leg did she run. The young girl scrambled backwards, gaining footing enough to spring back towards the door. The pipes comprising the walls around her shot steam in her face, and her feet splashed through more puddles of thick red. The sound of flesh grinding against metal echoed out behind her, the thumping sound quickening, growing closer and more violent with each step. Hiroko fell to her hands and knees as the ceiling lowered once more, scraping her nails against the metal floor to drag herself further. She never looked back. She didn't need to look back; she could feel the pounding inches away from her. Her arms ached, and just as she felt her body giving out feet from the exit, a cool hand wrapped itself around her outstretched arm.

Hiroko felt herself being pulled hard, and gasped for air as she was yanked out of the hall and heard the metal door behind her slam shut. She clambered away from the door, her heart

threatening to rip itself from her shaking chest, before looking up to see the arm that pulled her out. Her mother stood above her, gently pushing the dresser back into place to hide the metal door from sight. She looked down at Hiroko with an expression she couldn't determine. She wasn't scared, or angry, or even annoyed. She looked defeated.

"Don't go in there. That's no place for a child," she said in an uncharacteristically hesitant tone. "Your father and I will worry about it okay? Come on, let's get you back to bed." Hiroko didn't get the chance to ask any questions before her mother led her back to her room by the arm. She was scared and confused, but part of her wanted to believe it was all a bad dream she had, and her mother's lack of an explanation only served to further that excuse.

The thumping sound continued as normal when she got back into bed that night, as it did every subsequent night after that, though she tried to ignore it. Her parents got a divorce soon after that night. They never explained why to Hiroko, or what it was she had seen behind the metal door, though she was too young to know the exact questions to ask. She and her mother moved back to Kyoto while her father stayed in Takayama, working that same job. Hiroko enjoyed seeing her friends again, and her mother seemed a bit more lively in the following months, however she missed her father very much. She would go visit him once a month (he was far too busy to take care of her any more than that), and spend the weekend in Takayama. She would sit outside and read most of the day, shielding the sun from her eyes with one hand while holding a book in her other. Her father had to leave her alone in the house for most of the day, but he would come back late to make dinner and talk with her. He still seemed tired, but his eyes felt less empty. Instead, that emptiness had been filled with a soft sorrow that only seemed to dissipate when his gaze landed on Hiroko. His smile was authentic, but his frowns were laden with regret.

Hiroko never heard the thumping sound again when she would visit her father in that same house. She had checked one night after growing a macabre curiosity, pulled back the dresser once more to face the same fear she faced that night. The space behind the dresser was blank, no place beyond the wall. The metal door was gone.